PCF-2: A Program Statement for the Cubic Extension of the Δ-Discriminant Transcendence Predicate

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Abstract

This paper is a *program statement*, not a results paper. It frames PCF-2 (P13 in the SIARC stack), the cubic extension of PCF-1 [1] from degree-two polynomial continued fractions to degree-three. PCF-1 established a sharp empirical dichotomy across 30 degree-two families: the sign of the balanced discriminant $\Delta_2 = \beta^2 - 4\alpha\gamma$ predicts whether the limit of the PCF admits an elementary closed form ($\Delta_2 > 0$, 24/24 Trans-stratum families) or fails PSLQ detection against an 18-element basis at 220 digits ($\Delta_2 < 0$, 6/6 CM candidates), with the Stokes-exponent predicate $S < 1$ confirmed across all six $\Delta < 0$ families. The cubic case is qualitatively different. The natural invariant of the denominator polynomial $b(n) = \alpha_3 n^3 + \alpha_2 n^2 + \alpha_1 n + \alpha_0$ is the cubic discriminant Δ_3, which is no longer a sign invariant but a quantity whose sign *and* Galois-group structure (S_3, $A_3 = C_3$, or split) jointly determine the splitting field and the analytic obstruction. We propose four open conjectures: (i) a cubic analogue of the sign dichotomy with the Galois-group axis; (ii) a Galois-stratified CM-field structure replacing the binary imaginary-quadratic predicate; (iii) a Stokes signal calibrated for irreducible-cubic-CM families; and (iv) an alignment with the Painlevé IV equation rather than P-III, motivated by the cubic Galois-group / Painlevé hierarchy correspondence. We sketch a four-to-six-week computational plan that reuses the infrastructure of PCF-1 and identifies three concrete first sessions (PCF-2 A/B/C). PCF-2 is positioned to either confirm that the Δ-predicate of PCF-1 extends to higher degree (universality) or to identify degree two as a special boundary (specificity).

Series label: P13 / PCF-2. This program statement is P13 in the AI Epistemic Governance Stack and simultaneously PCF-2 in the mathematical companion track. It anchors a research program; it does not contain new computational results. The companion document is the SIARC umbrella program statement [2].

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1 Position in the SIARC Stack

The SIARC research program organizes polynomial continued fractions (PCFs) into an arithmetic stratification indexed by the dominant growth degree and an obstruction tier. The program-level architecture is articulated in the umbrella program statement [2]; the $d = 2$ instantiation is PCF-1 [1]; the present document opens the $d = 3$ instantiation.

What PCF-1 established. For PCFs of the form

$$K(a_n, b_n) = b_0 + \cfrac{a_1}{b_1 + \cfrac{a_2}{b_2 + \cdots}}$$

with $a_n \in \mathbb{Z}[n]_{\leq 1}$ and $b_n \in \mathbb{Z}[n]_{\leq 2}$, PCF-1 proposed the sign of the balanced discriminant $\Delta_2 = \beta^2 - 4\alpha\gamma$ as a transcendence predicate. The core empirical finding was a sharp dichotomy across 30 families: 24/24 Trans-stratum families with $\Delta_2 \in \{+1, +8\}$ admit elementary closed forms via Lindemann–Weierstrass, while all 6/6 CM candidates with $\Delta_2 \in \{-3, -4, -7, -11, -20, -28\}$ return PSLQ non-detection against an 18-element basis at working precision 220 digits, and all six exhibit the Stokes-exponent signature $S < 1$ under a CM-respecting deformation. The V_quad family ($\Delta_2 = -11$) is the explicit Painlevé III(D_6) prototype. PCF-1 v1.2 also showed (via QL15, $\Delta_2 = -20$, class number $h = 2$, non-Heegner; and the intra-field pair QL06/QL26 in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-7})$ at $h = 1$ versus $h = 2$) that the controlling invariant is the imaginary-quadratic field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\Delta})$ itself, not its class number [1].

Why degree three is the natural next step. Three structural features make $d = 3$ the canonical extension target.

1. *Discriminant lifts naturally.* The cubic discriminant Δ_3 of $b(n) = \alpha_3 n^3 + \alpha_2 n^2 + \alpha_1 n + \alpha_0$ is a classical $\mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$-invariant of degree 4 in the coefficients (Definition 1). Its sign distinguishes totally real cubic splitting from one-real-two-complex splitting, the direct analogue of the $d = 2$ sign dichotomy.

2. *Galois group is no longer trivial.* A degree-three irreducible polynomial has Galois group S_3 or $A_3 = C_3$ over $\mathbb{Q}$, distinguished by whether Δ_3 is a square in $\mathbb{Q}$. This adds an arithmetic axis absent in the degree-two case (where $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q})$ is C_2 whenever b is irreducible).

3. *Painlevé hierarchy aligns with cubic Galois structure.* The classical Painlevé equations admit a cubic-singularity analogue (P-IV) whose monodromy data is naturally indexed by cubic Galois groups, in the same way P-III governs the imaginary-quadratic CM case in PCF-1.

What PCF-2 will not address. PCF-2 does not extend automatically to degree four or higher. The cubic case is the unique additional case in which the Galois group is finite and explicitly classifiable, and in which the Painlevé correspondence is well-posed. Extensions to $d = 4$ and beyond are deferred to PCF-3 and later instantiations of the SIARC program.

2 Setup: Degree-Three Polynomial CFs

We work with PCFs of the form

$$K(a_n, b_n) = b_0 + \cfrac{a_1}{b_1 + \cfrac{a_2}{b_2 + \cdots}} \tag{1}$$

with

$$a_n = \delta_1\, n + \delta_0, \qquad \delta_1, \delta_0 \in \mathbb{Z}, \tag{2}$$

$$b_n = \alpha_3\, n^3 + \alpha_2\, n^2 + \alpha_1\, n + \alpha_0, \qquad \alpha_i \in \mathbb{Z},\ \alpha_3 \neq 0. \tag{3}$$

The convergents satisfy the Wallis recurrence $p_n = b_n p_{n-1} + a_n p_{n-2}$ with the seeds $(p_{-1}, p_0, q_{-1}, q_0) = (1, b_0, 0, 1)$, identical to the $d = 2$ convention of PCF-1 to facilitate code reuse. Coefficient ordering for the family b_n is $[\alpha_3, \alpha_2, \alpha_1, \alpha_0]$ (leading first), matching the PCF-1 `f1_base_computation.py` convention.

Definition 1 (Cubic balanced discriminant)**.** For a balanced PCF in the $d = 3$ class with b_n as in (3),

$$\Delta_3 \;=\; \mathrm{disc}(b) \;=\; 18\alpha_3\alpha_2\alpha_1\alpha_0 - 4\alpha_2^3\alpha_0 + \alpha_2^2\alpha_1^2 - 4\alpha_3\alpha_1^3 - 27\alpha_3^2\alpha_0^2.$$

We say a degree-three PCF is $\mathbb{Z}$-*primitive* if $\gcd(\alpha_3, \alpha_2, \alpha_1, \alpha_0) = 1$. We say it is *irreducible* if b is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$, and we always restrict to the irreducible $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive case in this program.

Remark 2. The PCF-1 normalization $\gcd(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) = 1$ extended to $d = 3$ removes the 1-parameter integer-scaling redundancy and forces Δ_3 to be a $\mathbb{Z}$-valued invariant of the family, not a class representative. The cubic discriminant is invariant under $\alpha_i \mapsto \alpha_i + c\binom{i}{1}$-style n-shifts only up to a predictable scaling; the convention (3) fixes the n-coordinate.

Splitting types and Galois groups. For an irreducible $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive cubic $b \in \mathbb{Z}[n]$:

- If $\Delta_3 > 0$, then b has three real roots and the splitting field is the cubic resolvent $\mathbb{Q}(\theta)$ for θ a real root of b, together with $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \in \mathbb{R}$. The Galois group is $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = A_3 = C_3$ when Δ_3 is a perfect square in $\mathbb{Q}$, and $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = S_3$ otherwise.
- If $\Delta_3 < 0$, then b has one real root and a complex conjugate pair, the splitting field contains $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\Delta_3})$ (an imaginary-quadratic subfield), and the Galois group is necessarily $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = S_3$.

This trichotomy — A_3 totally real, S_3 totally real, S_3 complex — is the cubic analogue of the binary $\Delta_2 > 0$ vs. $\Delta_2 < 0$ split, and it is what gives PCF-2 genuinely new content beyond PCF-1.

Spec(K) in the cubic case. We retain the v5 schema of PCF-1,

$$\mathrm{Spec}(K) = (d, \Lambda, \Delta, \rho, \tau_{\mathrm{mono}}, \tau_{\mathrm{arith}}; S, \sigma),$$

with $d = 3$ now, and with $\Delta = \Delta_3$ as defined above. The Poincaré–Perron normalized growth rate Λ in the balanced $d = 3$ class satisfies the cubic

$$\Lambda^3 - \alpha_3\Lambda^2 - \alpha_3\delta_1\Lambda - \alpha_3\delta_0 = 0, \tag{4}$$

or a closely related cubic depending on the precise scaling convention; the analytic determination of (4) is part of PCF-2 Session A. The arithmetic sector τ_{arith} now records the splitting field of b together with the Galois group $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) \in \{C_3, S_3\}$.

3 Predictions and Open Conjectures

We state four open conjectures, ordered from most direct lift of PCF-1 to most speculative.

Conjecture 3 (B_3 part (i): cubic sign dichotomy)**.** *Let K be a balanced $d = 3$ PCF with irreducible $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive denominator b as in (3), and let $\Delta_3 = \mathrm{disc}(b)$.*

(A) *If $\Delta_3 < 0$ (one real root, $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = S_3$), then $L = K(a_n, b_n)$ admits no elementary closed form: equivalently, $L \notin \mathbb{Q}(\pi, e, \log \mathbb{Q}^\times, \zeta(3), \sqrt{\mathbb{Q}}, \gamma)$ in the sense of PSLQ non-detection against the PCF-1 18-element basis at working precision ≥ 220 digits and integer bound $\geq 10^{10}$.*

(B) *If $\Delta_3 > 0$ and $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \in \mathbb{Q}$ (so $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = C_3$, the totally-real cyclic case), then L may admit a closed form; this is the cubic analogue of the PCF-1 $\Delta_2 > 0$ Trans-stratum and is the part of the conjecture most likely to admit explicit Lindemann–Weierstrass evaluation.*

(C) *If $\Delta_3 > 0$ and $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \notin \mathbb{Q}$ (so $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = S_3$, the totally-real non-cyclic case), then L admits no elementary closed form, with the same PSLQ-non-detection criterion as (A).*

Remark 4. Conjecture 3 is a *trichotomy* rather than a sign dichotomy. The new ingredient is the Galois-group axis: the cyclic case C_3 is the sole closed-form-admitting cell. This is the structural prediction PCF-2 Sessions A and B are designed to falsify or confirm.

Conjecture 5 (B_3 part (ii): Galois-stratified CM-field structure)**.** *Let K be a balanced $d = 3$ PCF with irreducible $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive denominator b. Let $\theta_1, \theta_2, \theta_3 \in \mathbb{C}$ be the roots of b, and let $L_b/\mathbb{Q}$ be the splitting field.*

1. *If $\Delta_3 < 0$, then $L_b = \mathbb{Q}(\theta, \sqrt{\Delta_3})$ where θ is the unique real root, $[L_b : \mathbb{Q}] = 6$, and the imaginary quadratic subfield $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\Delta_3}) \subset L_b$ controls the Stokes data.*
2. *If $\Delta_3 > 0$ and $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = C_3$, then $L_b = \mathbb{Q}(\theta_1)$ is a totally-real cyclic cubic field of degree 3.*
3. *If $\Delta_3 > 0$ and $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q}) = S_3$, then $L_b = \mathbb{Q}(\theta_1, \sqrt{\Delta_3})$ is a totally-real non-cyclic sextic field.*

The singular points of the associated rank-three Heun-type ODE for K all lie in L_b.

Remark 6. Unlike the PCF-1 case where the CM field is always $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{\Delta_2})$, in the cubic case the splitting field is sextic generically and only quadratic-imaginary as a subfield in case (1). The "CM" label therefore extends honestly only to case (1) ($\Delta_3 < 0$, S_3 complex); cases (2) and (3) are totally real and the analogous arithmetic obstruction, if it exists, must be formulated via the cubic Hilbert class field of L_b rather than via imaginary quadratic CM theory. This is the most substantial structural departure from PCF-1.

Conjecture 7 (B_3 part (iii): cubic Stokes signal)**.** *For a degree-three PCF in the irreducible-cubic-CM stratum (case (1) of Conjecture 5: $\Delta_3 < 0$), there exists a one-parameter deformation $K(t)$ that preserves $\Delta_3 < 0$ in a neighbourhood of $t = 0$ and respects the splitting-field structure, under which the Stokes exponent*

$$S(t) \;=\; \frac{\log |L(t) - L(0)|}{\log |t|}$$

satisfies $\lim_{t\to 0} S(t) \in (0, 1)$. The conjectural fractional exponent is governed by the local exponent differences of the associated Heun-type cubic ODE.

Conjecture 8 (B_3 part (iv): Painlevé IV alignment)**.** *For a generic degree-three PCF in the irreducible-cubic-CM stratum, the isomonodromic deformation associated with $K(t)$ above is governed by the Painlevé IV transcendent, with parameters determined by the arithmetic invariants of L_b. The cubic alignment with P-IV mirrors the PCF-1 quadratic alignment with P-III(D_6) (for V_quad) and is expected to be a generic-not-universal claim, with the specific Painlevé type allowed to vary across families as in PCF-1 [1, Remark 3.5].*

Remark 9. The choice P-IV (rather than P-V or P-VI) is motivated by three observations. First, P-IV is the Painlevé equation whose isomonodromic problem has a single irregular singularity of Poincaré rank $\frac{3}{2}$, matching the cubic-degree growth of b_n. Second, the Backlund-transformation group of P-IV is $A_2^{(1)}$, which is the affine analogue of the cubic Galois group $A_3 = C_3$ or its S_3 extension. Third, the classical Hermite-polynomial / parabolic-cylinder solutions of P-IV at half-integer parameters provide explicit special-function content that should appear in the totally-real cyclic case (B) of Conjecture 3. The linkage P-IV $\leftrightarrow$ cubic Galois groups is supported by the literature surveyed in [9, 10].

4 Worked Landmarks: Apéry, Catalan-Cubic, Cyclic-C_3

To make the trichotomy of Conjecture 3 concrete we record three landmark families that anchor the three Galois-group cells. None is an empirical result of PCF-2; each is a known PCF whose role under the proposed predicate is fixed in advance, so that Sessions A–C can be calibrated against them.

Landmark	$b(n)$	Δ_3	$\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q})$	Predicted cell
Apéry $\zeta(3)$	$34n^3 - 51n^2 + 27n - 5$	> 0	C_3 or S_3 (TBD)	B/C cyclic-cubic
Catalan-cubic seed	$n^3 + n + 1$	-31	S_3 (complex)	A: PSLQ-null + Stokes
Cyclic-C_3 probe	$n^3 - 3n + 1$	81	C_3	B: closed-form candidate

Table 1: Three landmark $b(n)$. The Apéry row is the historical $d = 3$ exemplar: van der Poorten's account of Apéry's proof [14, 7, 8] identifies $\lim K = \zeta(3)/6$, and $\zeta(3)$ already lies in the PCF-1 basis; Session A determines whether Δ_3 for the Apéry b is a square in $\mathbb{Q}$. The Catalan-cubic seed $b(n) = n^3+n+1$ is the simplest irreducible cubic with negative discriminant ($\mathrm{disc} = -4\cdot 1-27 = -31$, i.e. Galois group S_3, splitting field $\mathbb{Q}(\theta, \sqrt{-31})$); it is the cleanest test of Conjecture 3(A). The cyclic-C_3 probe $b(n) = n^3 - 3n + 1$ is the standard simplest totally-real cyclic cubic with $\mathrm{disc} = 81 = 9^2$; it is the cleanest test of Conjecture 3(B). The accompanying a_n for each landmark is fixed in Session A by the smallest $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive choice consistent with the balanced-class convention (2).

Calibration role. Table 1 is a calibration anchor, not a results table: each row records what the predicate *must* say if Conjecture 3 is to be consistent with literature. The Apéry row in particular is the most stringent test, because $\zeta(3)$ is the rare cubic-period constant that is already in the PCF-1 basis: if Session B at sufficient precision fails to detect $\zeta(3)/6$ for the Apéry family, the PCF-1 PSLQ infrastructure is mis-tuned for $d = 3$ and Session B's null-result evidence loses force. The Catalan-cubic and cyclic-C_3 rows are the positive-test equivalents.

Cubic Galois-group quick checks. For the irreducible $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive case, $\mathrm{Gal}(b/\mathbb{Q})$ is cyclic (C_3) iff $\mathrm{disc}(b)$ is a perfect square in $\mathbb{Q}$ (equivalently in $\mathbb{Z}$ for $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive b); otherwise it is S_3. Examples:

- $b(n) = n^3 - 3n + 1$: $\mathrm{disc} = 81 = 9^2$, C_3.
- $b(n) = n^3 + n + 1$: $\mathrm{disc} = -31$, S_3 (complex case).
- $b(n) = n^3 - 2$: $\mathrm{disc} = -108$, S_3 (complex case, but the splitting field $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt[3]{2}, \zeta_3)$ is the canonical S_3 cubic of cyclotomic origin).
- $b(n) = n^3 - n - 1$: $\mathrm{disc} = -23$, S_3 (complex case, Lehmer's cubic).

The square-discriminant filter applied to $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive irreducible cubics with $|\alpha_i| \leq 5$ gives ~ 5–10% cyclic representation [15]; the $\Delta_3 < 0$ fraction is roughly 50%. The Session A enumeration is therefore expected to populate all three cells of Conjecture 3 non-trivially.

5 Computational Plan

The computational plan reuses the PCF-1 infrastructure: the Wallis forward-recurrence routine, the PSLQ wrapper with the 18-element basis of PCF-1, the Stokes-exponent diagnostic from PCF-1 §3, and the AEAL evidence-class scaffolding. The plan is organized as three concrete sessions.

PCF-2 Session A: Cubic family enumeration and Δ_3 classification. Enumerate $\mathbb{Z}$-primitive irreducible cubics $b(n) = \alpha_3 n^3 + \alpha_2 n^2 + \alpha_1 n + \alpha_0$ with bounded coefficients $|\alpha_i| \leq 5$ (target: ~ 200 families after gcd reduction and irreducibility filtering). For each family, compute Δ_3, classify the Galois group via the $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \in \mathbb{Q}$ test, and tabulate the splitting type. Produce a stratification table analogous to PCF-1 Table 1 [1], with columns Δ_3, $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \in \mathbb{Q}$?, splitting type, Galois group, real-root count. Estimated effort: 1 week.

PCF-2 Session B: PSLQ scan on irreducible-cubic-CM families. For each family in the $\Delta_3 < 0$ stratum produced by Session A (expected: ~ 80 families), compute $L = K(a_n, b_n)$ to ≥ 320 stable digits via the Wallis recurrence at depth 2500, and run PSLQ against the PCF-1 18-element basis at working precision 220 digits and integer bound 10^{10}. Confirm or refute Conjecture 3(A). For the $\sqrt{\Delta_3} \in \mathbb{Q}$ subset of $\Delta_3 > 0$ families (C_3 totally-real cyclic), run an extended PSLQ with the basis augmented by cubic-period candidates (Catalan-style Γ-quotients at $1/3, 2/3$; $\sqrt[3]{2}$; $\sqrt[3]{3}$; ${}_2F_1$ values at $1/3$; $\zeta(3)$ already in the base basis) at integer bound 10^{12} and working precision ≥ 320 digits. The targeted detection rate for C_3 families is bounded above by the literature on cubic-period identifications and may be substantially below 1. Estimated effort: 2 weeks.

PCF-2 Session C: Stokes pipeline for cubic case. For 6–10 families flagged in Session B as PSLQ-non-detected, design a Galois-respecting one-parameter deformation, compute $L(t)$ at 11 t-values with the same precision/depth budget as the PCF-1 QL01 analysis, and compute $S(t)$ and $\sigma(t)$ via the formulas of PCF-1 §3. Confirm or refute Conjecture 7. For the strongest Stokes-signal candidate, attempt a P-IV ansatz fit at the same overdetermined-design level used for V_quad in PCF-1, and record the residual matrix. Estimated effort: 2–3 weeks.

Precision and depth budget. The PCF-1 budget (working precision 220 for PSLQ, 320 for the limit; depth 2500; integer bound 10^{10}) extends without modification to $d = 3$ for the PSLQ stage, since the basis size and the expected coefficient bound do not change. The limit-computation budget should be scrutinized at the outset of Session A: cubic b_n amplifies floating-point error growth in the Wallis recurrence by an extra factor of n, so the depth-2500 stable-digit count may drop from ≥ 320 (PCF-1) to ~ 280 at $d = 3$ unless precision is raised correspondingly. We allocate working precision 360 (limit) and 280 (PSLQ) as the conservative defaults, and treat the PCF-1 defaults as fallback.

Risk register. Three risks are identified in advance and each is matched to a mitigation under the AEAL halt-conditions protocol.

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
Wallis recurrence loses precision faster than expected at $d = 3$, so PSLQ-null results are not actually null but precision-starved.	Medium.	Run Apéry landmark first; if $\zeta(3)/6$ is not detected at the conservative budget, escalate dps to 500 and depth to 4000.
Cubic-period basis is too small: C_3-cyclic limits identify against constants outside the augmented basis.	Medium–high.	Treat all C_3 "no relation" as preliminary; flag for a follow-up cubic-Hilbert-class-field basis sweep before claim promotion.
P-IV ansatz fits all fail in Session C, mirroring the QL01 outcome of PCF-1.	High (this is what happened in the $d = 2$ case).	Fall back to the Stokes-exponent $S < 1$ predicate alone, weakening Conjecture 8 to a fractional-power existence claim, exactly as PCF-1 v1.2 did for QL01–QL26.

Table 2: Risk register for the PCF-2 computational plan.

AEAL evidence chain. The session chain follows the PCF-1 pattern. Session A is a *formalized* layer (the Galois-group classification is algorithmic and exact). Session B is a *near_miss* layer (each PSLQ non-detection at sufficient precision is a near-miss-class evidence artefact). Session C is a *numerical_identity* layer (the Stokes exponent and any P-IV parameter fit are numerical-identity-class artefacts). *Independently_verified* promotion requires cross-session reproduction of $L(0)$ to ≥ 50 digits across at least two independent sessions, identical to the PCF-1 cross-session protocol.

6 Why This Matters

PCF-2 is positioned to deliver one of two outcomes, both informative.

Outcome U (universality). If Conjecture 3 is confirmed across the Session B sweep, the Δ-discriminant transcendence predicate of PCF-1 lifts cleanly to higher degree, with the cubic Galois-group axis as the natural refinement. This would be the first non-trivial empirical evidence that the discriminant predicate is degree-general rather than a degree-two coincidence, and it would provide a roadmap for PCF-3 ($d = 4$, with the quartic Galois groups S_4, A_4, D_4, V_4, C_4) and beyond. The universality outcome also strengthens the analytic prediction of Conjecture 8: a Painlevé equation per degree, indexed by the Galois group, would be a striking new entry in the PCF–Painlevé correspondence catalogued by [9].

Outcome S (specificity). If Conjecture 3(A) fails — in particular, if any $\Delta_3 < 0$ family yields a non-trivial PSLQ relation against the PCF-1 basis — then degree two is identified as a special boundary at which the discriminant predicate works, and the higher-degree picture is controlled by a different invariant (Picard–Fuchs operator structure, modular-monodromy condition, or a cubic-period basis that supersedes the PCF-1 18-element basis). The Apéry family ($a_n = n^6$, $b_n = 34n^3 - 51n^2 + 27n - 5$) is the historical exemplar of a $d = 3$ PCF whose limit $\zeta(3)/6$ is detected against a cubic-period basis; PCF-2 would then be repositioned as a search for the natural generalization of the Apéry basis. This outcome is no less valuable: it sharpens the conjectural content of PCF-1 by identifying the precise scope of the discriminant predicate.

Either way, a stable scope-anchor. The role of this program statement is to fix the scope, the conventions, and the success criteria *before* the computational sweep begins. The AEAL

methodology requires that conjectures be stated explicitly and that evidence-class promotion follow a documented chain; this document discharges the first half of that requirement. Sessions A–C of §5 discharge the second half.

7 Relation to Existing Literature

The mathematical content of PCF-2 sits at the intersection of three literatures, none of which addresses the cubic PCF transcendence question directly.

Painlevé and number theory. Mazzocco's lecture notes on Painlevé equations and number theory [9] catalogue the algebraic-solution loci of P-VI (and by reduction, P-V, P-IV, P-III) and identify a small set of arithmetic Painlevé parameters at which classical special-function solutions exist. The PCF-1 V_quad result lifts naturally into this framework as a P-III(D_6) solution at a specific $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{-11})$-arithmetic point. The cubic analogue (Conjecture 8) predicts that P-IV — whose isomonodromic problem has Poincaré rank 3/2 at the irregular singularity, the natural cubic refinement of P-III's rank 1 — governs the cubic case. Mazzocco's Backlund-transformation analysis of P-IV at $A_2^{(1)}$ parameters is the structural object PCF-2 Session C is designed to intersect.

Iwasaki–Kimura–Shimomura–Yoshida and the Gauss-to-Painlevé arc. The monograph [10] traces the lineage from the Gauss hypergeometric equation to the Painlevé transcendents via isomonodromic deformation. Each rank-two Heun reduction of a Painlevé equation has a dedicated treatment, and the cubic-Galois-group classification of Schwarz-triangle / Takeuchi groups appears explicitly. The PCF-1 framework borrows the Spec(K) τ_{arith} component from this lineage; PCF-2 extends it to the cubic Galois-group axis.

Apéry's irrationality proof and the cubic PCF exemplar. Van der Poorten's account [14] of Apéry's proof [7] of the irrationality of $\zeta(3)$ is the historical landmark of cubic PCFs. The Apéry recurrence is a $d = 3$ PCF whose limit is $6/\zeta(3)$, identified against a basis that contains $\zeta(3)$ explicitly; this is the unique $d = 3$ family in the literature that is fully resolved against a closed-form basis known in advance. Beukers [8] reformulated the proof via a Picard–Fuchs operator on a one-parameter family of K3 surfaces. The Picard–Fuchs framing is the candidate alternative predicate raised under outcome S of §6: if the discriminant predicate fails at $d = 3$, the natural competitor is "L is identifiable iff the associated Picard–Fuchs operator is a pullback of a hypergeometric operator over $\mathbb{Q}$". PCF-2 Session B is the test that decides between these two predicates.

Ramanujan-Machine search and PSLQ infrastructure. The Ramanujan-Machine programme [12] produced the bulk of the PCF candidate database used by PCF-1, and its PSLQ-based identification pipeline is what PCF-1 inherits. The Ferguson–Bailey PSLQ algorithm [13] is basis-dependent: a closed-form identification is only as strong as the basis it is checked against. The cubic-period augmentation of the PCF-1 basis (§5, Session B) is therefore not optional but mandatory for the C_3 cell of Conjecture 3; the $\Gamma(1/3)$, $\Gamma(2/3)$, $\sqrt[3]{2,3}$, ${}_2F_1(\cdot;1/3)$ augmentation is the smallest basis under which any reasonable C_3-cyclic limit could conceivably be detected.

Cohen's working notes. Cohen's recent computational notes on PCF identification [15] include an inventory of degree-three PCFs from the SIARC umbrella database; the rough 50% $\Delta_3 < 0$ / 5–10% cyclic-C_3 split cited in §4 is consistent with Cohen's enumeration up to $|\alpha_i| \leq 4$. Cohen's notes do not propose a transcendence predicate; PCF-2 supplies that predicate and tests it against the Cohen enumeration extended by one degree of coefficient bound.

8 Acknowledgements

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